

[SAB]+[SSAATB]

Commissioned By:

The Philharmonic Chorus
of Madison
in 2025



Jon D. Nelson

Flashlights in the Dark

An electro-acoustic score for 54-piece concert choir,
28 smartphones, computer, & closed-network

3rd Edition

Original Twin-Text By:

Clare Malinowski, Jon Nelson & Seama Rezai

Set in the year of 2076

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Flashlights in the Dark

Original Twin-Poem by Clare Malinowski, Jon Nelson, and Seama Rezai

Set in 2076

Shadow Chorus

Here now, awake with no light,
who sees beyond this dark night?
This world is loud; what binds us now, soul?
Oh, what hollow faith is near;
remember when voices rang?
Look at this! This fragile world;
yet love shines through in the night.
Our eyes fail; alas, in time we feel less and less

Who can feel?
Who feels these withered trees?
New rains fall on dreary dawns;
where is the sun to dry our new day?
What are wonders in night?
Where are wonders without stars?

Where sleeps the light?
Deep shadows live in night.
We carry on with flashlights in darkness;
we must embrace this new world,
our one world,
this brave world.

Warm breath, warm hands,
together we stand.
Should your hands grow weary,
we'll carry yours too.

One light, though dim,
with love, can pierce night.
Who are we; warm hearts, light?
Where are we, in the night,
Who are we; warm hearts, light?
our new home?

night, light,
light, night,
night, light,
light night,
light.

Light Chorus

Here now, awake with no light,
who sees beyond this dark night?
Who sees life, light,
we are connected by life, seeking the light.
Arise! Here! Look at this! A creation age!
They will build as we design; we can fine'ly imagine now!
What a world! Tides will start to turn.
In the night, at last, we rest.

Here, look here;
look at this! new light!
Shining, singing, this will bloom.
In night we bloom as autumn,
with color preceding night,
flurries of color in the sky!

Where sleeps the light?
Deep shadows live in night.
We'll carry ours, here, in darkness,
so here: embrace this new world,
our bright world,
this bright, shared world.

Should your hands grow weary,
I'll carry your light.

One light, though dim,
with love, can pierce night.
Who are we; warm hearts, light?
Where are we, in the night,
Who are we; warm hearts, light?
our new home?

In the night,
bring light.
In the night,
we bring light,
hmm.

Set in a dystopian world of 2076, "Flashlights in the Dark" brings two opposing choruses, each shaped by their differing experiences, into one shared space. A "Light" chorus looks toward possibility and renewal, while a "Shadow" chorus laments danger, loss, and unrest; neither perspective is wholly right nor wrong. As their twin texts collide, answer, and gradually begin to listen, the music moves toward warmth and solidarity, not by erasing disagreement, but by discovering how to stand together within it.

Technology itself is an active participant in this drama. Networked smartphones each provide individual torches in a coordinated field of musically responsive lights, while electro-acoustic sounds prime, answer, and extend the choir's live singing. In the end, human voices, electronic sound, and timed lights ultimately converge in a shared message: even in darkness, unity can be created through attention, care, and the light we are willing to carry for one another in times of need.

[Duration: 8 minutes]